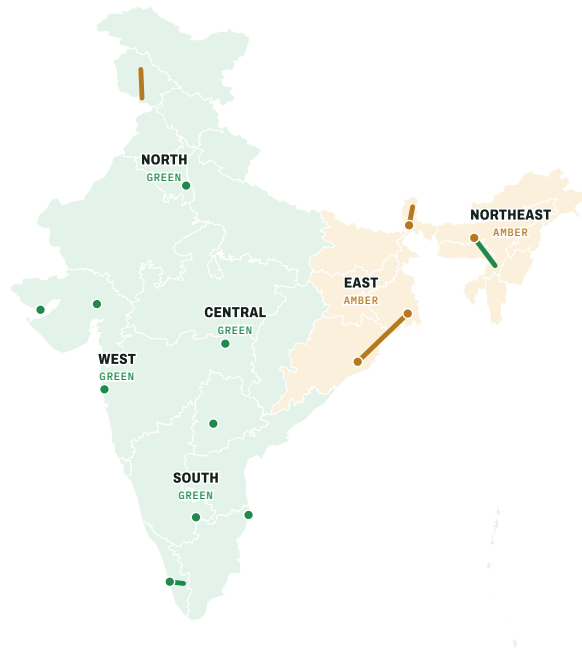


Money and freight got dearer

● NETWORK: AMBER

The big sales have begun^{1,2}, and yesterday made the peak dearer: the RBI raised rates for the first time since 2023³, and Mumbai's air cargo is running days late since its freighters moved to Navi Mumbai⁴.

HOW'S EACH REGION HOLDING UP?



DATES TO WATCH

● 8–9 Oct Sales open: Amazon, then Flipkart

● Thu 8 Oct Odisha bandh

● 8–15 Oct NH-10 night closures

● Sat 10 Oct Kolkata Mahalaya truck ban⁵

● 11–19 Oct Navratri

● 13–27 Oct Kolkata Puja curbs and immersions⁵

● 26 Oct–5 Nov NH-10 night closures, again

● Sat 31 Oct Delhi's BS-IV exemption ends

● GREEN the sale season as usual, which can still be busy

● AMBER something beyond the season is slowing freight

● RED something is stopping freight across a state or a route

North

● GREEN

The march is over and Delhi is still busy: its roads ran 11 points above usual yesterday⁶, after 17 on Tuesday, when the INDIA bloc marched through central Delhi⁷. Is that the sale, or something more? Too early to say, so it stays Green.

West

● GREEN

Kandla passed 100 million tonnes for the year on Tuesday, 51 days sooner than last year and the fastest it has ever got there⁸. The queue shows it: 60 ships were waiting off the port that day, against about 50 on a usual day since July⁹. Busy, not stuck, so the West stays Green.

South

● GREEN

Chennai's DP World terminal had its busiest month in a decade in September¹⁰, and the port's new Port Setu truck tracking should buy freight stations one extra trip in six¹¹. Exporters still face Colombo: ships skipping it leave boxes from Tuticorin, Cochin and Chennai behind¹².

East

● AMBER

Odisha's bandh runs 6 am to 6 pm today with autos off¹³, and by 7:30 Congress workers had stopped the Sambalpur–Puri train at Sambalpur, though no highway blockade had been reported¹⁴. NH-16 into Kolkata normally carries about 7,000 heavy trucks a day at the Debra plaza¹⁵. If Kolkata's hubs back up, the Northeast feels it most: by my estimate, 30% of the parcels crossing Kolkata have no other road¹⁵. Delhi–Kolkata truck rentals ran 13% above last year in September¹⁶.

Northeast

● AMBER

NH-10 into Sikkim stays shut at night till 15th October, the one road here I'm still watching.

Central

● GREEN

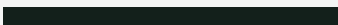
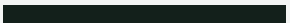
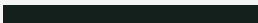
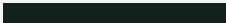
Rain over Chhattisgarh and east Madhya Pradesh ends by Friday¹⁷, and nothing beyond the season turned up there. I'll take that.

NETWORK INSIGHTS

1 Inventory and interest

HIGH CONFIDENCE

Truck rentals in September, % above last year¹⁶

Delhi–Kolkata		+13%
Bengaluru–Mumbai		+11%
Kolkata–Guwahati		+10%
Delhi–Mumbai		+9%

The RBI raised the repo rate by a quarter point to 5.5% yesterday, its first hike since February 2023, and the RBI governor said the next move can only be a hike or a pause³. It lands on a busy network: diesel demand rose 4.9% in September¹⁸, Tata's heavy-truck sales were up 44%¹⁹, and truck rentals finished the month above last year on every route Shriram tracks, Bengaluru–Mumbai up 11%¹⁶.

The exposure sits with whoever is building Diwali stock on borrowed money, and with fleets that bought trucks on loans this year.

2 Navi Mumbai, and the three-day wait

Mumbai's air cargo, exports and imports

● AMBER · HIGH COST OF DELAY · HIGH CONFIDENCE

Mumbai's two airports handled 27% of India's international air freight in August²⁰. Its freighters moved from the main airport to the new one at Navi Mumbai on 1st August, and on 5th October Challenge Group suspended its flights there, saying the setup isn't reliable yet²¹. Forwarders report imports held 72 hours or more, too few dollies and covered bays, and reroutes adding 20–25% to costs⁴. Adani's eight airports, both Mumbai ones included, have stopped Russia-bound cargo, stranding about 150 tonnes of pharma, machinery and spares²².

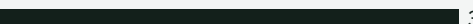
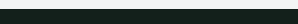
So India's second-busiest air gateway is learning on the job in its busiest month. The exposure sits with pharma and electronics shippers whose Mumbai bookings have no slack for three days.

3 More boxes, and fewer ships

Containers through the major ports, exports and imports

● AMBER · HIGH COST OF DELAY · HIGH CONFIDENCE

Boxes at JNPA waiting for trains inland, TEUs^{23,24}

5 Oct		3,835
7 Oct		2,526

Major ports handled 12% more containers from April to September than a year earlier, and JNPA 18% more, on the ports association's provisional count²⁵. Is the quay

the bottleneck? Not this week: on 7th October JNPA's yard was half full, trucks turned round in 1.4 hours, and 2,526 boxes were waiting for trains inland²⁴, down from 3,835 two days earlier²³. The squeeze is actually on the water. C.H. Robinson expects India–North America to stay short of vessel space until at least mid- to late October, with Colombo, Nhava Sheva and Mundra congested, and warns of rolled bookings and longer lead times¹².

So a box can clear the gate in hours and still miss its ship. The exposure sits with exporters whose US orders came off the line late, because a late box is the first one rolled.

THE LANES I'M WATCHING

NH-16 through Odisha

● AMBER

EAST COAST TRUNK, KOLKATA–CHENNAI

Today's bandh, so Amber rather than Red until a report shows the highway itself blocked, and Amber again tomorrow while the trucks clear.

NH-10 Siliguri–Gangtok

● AMBER

SIKKIM'S ONE AND ONLY TRUNK ROAD

Shut to all vehicles 9 pm to 6 am on the Sevoke–Rangpo stretch till 15th October, and again 26th October–5th November²⁶.

NH-44 Jammu–Srinagar

● AMBER

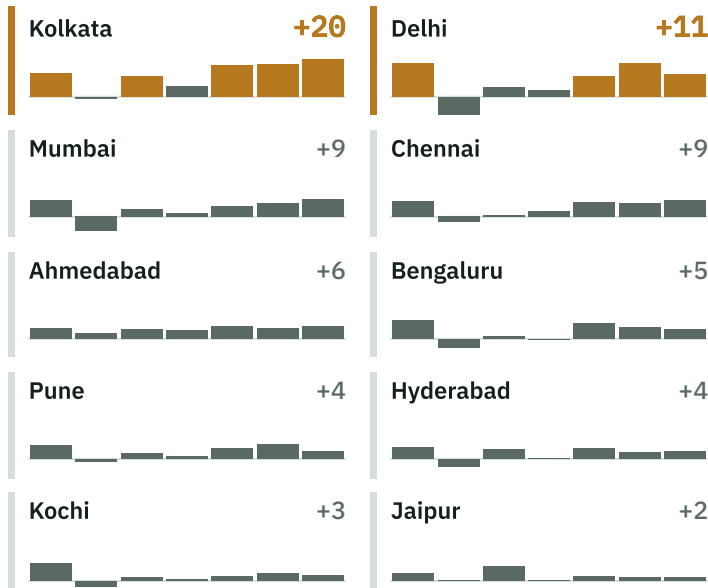
KASHMIR'S ALL-WEATHER LINK

Single lane at Udhampur and between Marog and Nachlana, tankers past Chenani only from 5 pm to 6 am, and night travel discouraged²⁷.

MEASURED THIS MORNING

City roads against usual, daily, 1–7 Oct⁶ amber = 10+ over

Kolkata and Delhi stand out: 10+ points over usual on 7 Oct, Kolkata on 5 of the last 7 days and Delhi on 4.



HOW I RATE THIS, AND WHAT I CAN'T SEE

I rate against the season, because a sale week is never going to look like a quiet week in April, right? A Red road drags down the hubs at both ends, and a hub stays Amber about two days after its cause clears, longer after a Red. Air shows up only with measured numbers (AAI, WorldACD). Confidence is High when the facts are dated and primary or measured, Medium when they rest on a proxy or a forecast. If I am wrong, we'll find out in the subsequent weeks.

Built from public sources only. The ratings are my judgement on the likelihood of on-time delivery or cost-impact, not measured service levels or actual cost estimates. Map boundaries: [DataMeet](#), CC BY 4.0.

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